Prerequisites and objectives

- Prerequisites are the dictionary ADT, modular arithmetic, expectation, linked lists, and amortized analysis.
- Separate hash functions, collision resolution, and resizing policies. State the assumptions behind each performance claim.
- Trace chaining, linear probing, tombstone deletion, and rehashing.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Dictionary ADT and collisions

- A dictionary maps each unique key to a value. Operations include find, insert-or-update, and erase.
- A hash function $h : U \to \{0, \ldots, m-1\}$ maps a key universe into m buckets. Collisions are unavoidable when $|U| > m$.
- Equal keys must have equal hashes. The converse fails. Different colliding keys still need equality comparison.
- A hash is not a unique identifier. Comparing hashes without keys turns a collision into a data error.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Hash functions and probability spaces

- The division method is h(k)=k mod m. Keys with matching modular structure may all enter one bucket.
- Randomly selecting a function differs from assuming uniform input. A universal family requires collision probability at most 1/m for every distinct fixed x, y, over the random choice of h.
- If input is fixed before h is selected, universal hashing bounds expected collisions through internal randomness. Adaptive adversaries may require stronger assumptions.
- Cryptographic hashing and ordinary hash tables address different threat models. Output bit length alone does not establish resistance to attacks.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Separate chaining and load factor

- Each bucket stores a list or another collection of keys sharing a hash. Load factor $\alpha = n/m$ can exceed 1.
- With uniform hashing, an independent unsuccessful query has expected bucket length α. For a universal collision bound and a fixed query key outside a fixed stored set, the expectation is at most α. Both give expected $O(1+\alpha)$ search under constant-time key operations.
- Successful-search expectation also depends on insertion order and query distribution. Standard uniform models give $O(1+\alpha)$.
- All n keys can still occupy one bucket, giving $\Theta(n)$ worst-case search. An expected guarantee does not eliminate the worst case.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Worked chaining example

- Let m=7, h(k)=k mod 7, and insert `10,17,24,8`.
- Appending within a bucket gives bucket 3 as `[10,17,24]` and bucket 1 as `[8]`. Other buckets are empty.
- Finding 24 scans three keys. Finding absent 31 also scans bucket 3. A small global n/m does not guarantee a short particular search.
- Tree-based buckets can support other requirements or control severe collisions. Their different implementation and costs are not automatic properties of basic chaining.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Complete chaining dictionary operations

```
find(k):
    j=hash(k) mod m
    for node in bucket[j]:
        if equal(node.key,k): return reference(node.value)
    return absent
insert_or_update(k,v):
    j=hash(k) mod m
    for node in bucket[j]:
        if equal(node.key,k): node.value=v; return updated
    prepend newly constructed pair(k,v) to bucket[j]; n+=1
erase(k):
    j=hash(k) mod m; predecessor=dummy_before(bucket[j])
    while predecessor.next!=null:
        if equal(predecessor.next.key,k): unlink and release; n-=1; return true
        predecessor=predecessor.next
    return false
```

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Complete chaining dictionary operations (continued)

This code prepends, unlike the earlier append-based example. After 10,17,24 enter bucket 3, the chain is [24,17,10]. Find 24 compares once; find 31 compares three times. Erasing 17 leaves [24,10]; reinserting 24 updates its value without increasing n. Both insertion orders implement the same dictionary but differ in individual successful-search costs.

A dummy predecessor may be temporary rather than stored user data. Removing the first node must update the bucket head. Expected chain length depends on the hashing model; collisions can still make worst-case search $\Theta(n)$. Skipping duplicate checks changes a unique-key dictionary into multimap semantics.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Whole-table collision pairs versus a fixed query

```
// S is fixed before the random function h is selected.
tau=0
for each unordered pair {x,y} in S:
    tau += indicator(h(x)==h(y))
E[tau] = sum_{unordered {x,y}} Pr(h(x)==h(y))
```

An unsuccessful fixed query compares one key with n stored keys, giving expected chain length at most n/m. Whole-table collision counting has $\binom{n}{2}$ unordered pairs. A universal family bounds each pair's collision probability by $1/m$, hence $\mathbb{E}[\tau] \le n(n-1)/(2m)$. Exact pair probability 1/m gives equality. Both calculations use linearity without independence among all pair events, but n/m is not the table's total collision count.

If $m = \Theta(n^{4/3})$, total expected collisions are $O(n^{2/3})$, while a fixed unsuccessful query has $\mathbb{E}[X] \le n/m = O(n^{-1/3})$, plus the unavoidable bucket-access constant. With m=Θ(n), Θ(n) total expected pairs remain compatible with expected O(1) per query. A bucket of b keys contributes b(b−1)/2 collision pairs, not b−1.

Whole-table collision pairs versus a fixed query (continued)

Worst-case expectation here means $\max_{|S|=n} \mathbb{E}_h[\tau(S,h)]$. Fix any S before choosing h. Universality gives the same bound for each such set. This differs from $\mathbb{E}_h[\max_{|S|=n} \tau(S,h)]$, which allows the input to depend on the observed function. The quantifier order changes the model. For nonnegative τ and $a > 0$, Markov's inequality gives $\Pr(\tau \geq a) \leq \mathbb{E}[\tau]/a$. A small expectation does not guarantee zero collisions for every selected function.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Constructing a universal family and rejecting false randomization

```
// p prime, keys are distinct vectors in F_p^2.
choose a,b independently and uniformly from 0..p-1
h(a,b,(x1,x2))=(a*x1+b*x2) mod p
// A random output translation of fixed g:
g_c(x)=(g(x)+c) mod m
```

For distinct vectors x,y, difference $\delta=(x1-y1,x2-y2)$ is nonzero. If $\delta1\neq0$, fixing any b leaves exactly one solution a to $a\delta1+b\delta2=0$ because nonzero field elements are invertible. Collision probability is exactly 1/p. If $\delta1=0$, then $\delta2\neq0$ and solve uniquely for b instead. The proof includes the function a=b=0; one all-colliding function does not invalidate the family's expected guarantee.

For p=11 and keys (0,0),(1,0),(0,1),(1,1), six pairs each collide under exactly 11 of 121 coefficient choices. Total expected collisions are 6/11. Function a=b=0 makes all six pairs collide, an allowed low-probability outcome within the same expectation.

Constructing a universal family and rejecting false randomization (continued)

By contrast, randomly translating a fixed g preserves collisions: g_c(x)=g_c(y) exactly when g(x)=g(y). With g(x1,x2)=x1, keys (3,1),(3,7) always collide, so this is not universal. Reducing a large integer modulo p before hashing can likewise collapse distinct keys prematurely. Encode keys $0..p^2-1$ injectively as two base-p digits rather than discarding the higher digit.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Slot states in open addressing

- Every element resides in the table. A key searches probe sequence `h(k,0),h(k,1),…`. Normally n<m is required.
- Slots are Never-used, Occupied, or Deleted. The three states have different meanings.
- Search may stop at Never-used because insertion could not have passed it to place the same key later. Deleted does not permit stopping.
- Insertion may remember the first Deleted slot but must continue checking for an existing equal key, avoiding duplicate dictionary keys.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Linear probing and primary clustering

- Linear probing uses $h(k,i)=(h_o(k)+i) \bmod m$. Consecutive access has locality but forms contiguous occupied clusters.
- With m=7, inserting 10,17,24 places them in slots 3,4,5.
- Searching for 31 probes 3,4,5,6 before finding empty, taking four probes. Additional keys entering this region extend the cluster.
- Ideal uniform-probing formulas do not directly apply because linear-probing sequences are strongly correlated.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Deletion counterexample and tombstones

- Delete 17. If slot 4 becomes Never-used, search for 24 incorrectly stops there.
- Mark slot 4 Deleted instead. Search crosses it and finds 24 in slot 5.
- Many tombstones lengthen searches even when current n is small. Effective occupancy must account for Occupied and Deleted slots.
- Backshift deletion is another strategy, but it must preserve probe reachability. Arbitrarily shifting a following element left is insufficient.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Double hashing and probe coverage

- Double hashing uses $h(k,i)=(h_1(k)+i\cdot h_2(k)) \bmod m$. The step and m must be coprime to cover all m slots.
- With m=8 and step 2, only four slots of the same parity are visited. Insertion can fail despite empty slots elsewhere.
- A prime m with $1 \le h_2(k) < m$ ensures coprimality. Power-of-two capacities can use odd steps.
- Quadratic probing needs specified coefficients, capacity, and load restrictions. Writing $h+i^2$ alone does not guarantee reaching every empty slot.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-s

Complete open-addressed lookup, insertion, and deletion

```
locate_or_slot(key):
    first_deleted=none
    for i=0..m-1:
        j=probe(key,i)
        if state[j]==Occupied and equal(keys[j],key): return found(j)
        if state[j]==Deleted and first_deleted==none: first_deleted=j
        if state[j]==Never_used:
            return absent(first_deleted if first_deleted!=none else j)
    if first_deleted is set: return absent(first_deleted)
    return full
insert_or_update(k,v):
    result=locate_or_slot(k)
```

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Complete open-addressed lookup, insertion, and deletion (continued)

```
    if result is found(j): values[j]=v; return
    if n+1>3*m/4: rehash(2*m); result=locate_or_slot(k)
    else if deleted>m/8: rehash(m); result=locate_or_slot(k)
    j=result.slot
    if state[j]==Deleted: deleted-=1
    construct pair(k,v) at j; state[j]=Occupied; n+=1
erase(k):
    if locate_or_slot(k) is found(j):
        destroy item; state[j]=Deleted; n-=1; deleted+=1
        if m>minimum_capacity and n<m/4:
            rehash(max(minimum_capacity,m//2))
```

Require full probe coverage; double hashing needs a coprime step. With no Never-used slots, a Deleted slot can still accept insertion after a full duplicate check. For m=7, insert 10,17,24 at 3,4,5. Deleting 17 marks slot 4 Deleted. Search 24 probes 3→4→5. Insert 31 probes through Never-used 6 before reusing 4. A later insert of key 24 must update slot 5 instead of creating a duplicate at a tombstone.

Lin Cing https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Complete open-addressed lookup, insertion, and deletion (continued)

The m-probe limit terminates on a full table. Occupied owns a live pair; Deleted retains reachability but no live pair. Reading its destroyed key is a lifetime error. Hash and equality costs for long keys are separate from probe work.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

The model behind expected probe bounds

- Ideal uniform hashing assumes each key's probe permutation is uniform and independent of the prior table history. With $\alpha<1$ and no tombstones, unsuccessful search takes at most $1/(1-\alpha)$ expected probes.
- In the same model, equally likely successful queries among keys inserted without deletion have bound $(1/\alpha)\ln(1/(1-\alpha))$ for $\alpha>0$.
- At $\alpha=0.9$ the unsuccessful bound is 10. It depends on load and diverges as α approaches 1.
- These are not exact linear-probing formulas. They omit tombstones, hash computation, and long-key equality costs.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Deriving ideal probe upper bounds

- Assume m−n Never-used slots, no tombstones, and a uniform random probe permutation independent of the occupied set. The first i probes all hit occupied slots with probability $(n)_i/(m)_i \le \alpha^i$, using falling factorials.
- For probe count X, the tail-sum identity gives $\mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_{i\ge 0} \Pr(X > i) \le \sum_{i\ge 0} \alpha^i = 1/(1-\alpha)$. Both α<1 and absence of tombstones enter this proof.
- For equally likely successful queries among n inserted, undeleted keys, average over insertion loads j/m. Since 1/(1−x) increases, its left rectangle sum is bounded by its integral: $\mathbb{E}[X] \le \frac{1}{n}\sum_{j=0}^{n-1} \frac{1}{1-j/m} \le \frac{1}{\alpha}\ln\frac{1}{1-\alpha}$.
- This derives the bound from the probability model. Linear probing's contiguous clusters do not satisfy the random-permutation premise.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Resizing must recompute placement

- Changing capacity changes the key-to-slot mapping. Reinsert existing keys rather than merely copying old slots into a larger array.
- Doubling at a fixed load threshold scans and allocates $\Theta(n)$ storage when $m=\Theta(n)$. Reinsertion also has expected $\Theta(n)$ cost under suitable random assumptions and a load bounded away from 1. It need not be worst-case linear under arbitrary collisions.
- These conditions give expected amortized $O(1)$ insertion. The claim combines probability assumptions with accounting across a sequence. It is not worst-case constant time per operation.
- Equal growth and shrink thresholds can trigger repeated rebuilding under alternating updates. Distinct thresholds avoid this oscillation.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Rehash relocation and expected analysis

```
rehash(new_m):
    allocate new_m Never_used slots
    choose compatible new hash parameters if required
    for each old Occupied pair (k,v):
        insert into new table using its new probe sequence
    commit new table; deleted=0; preserve n; release old table
```

For keys 10,17,24,8 with m=7, buckets are 3:[10,17,24],1:[8]. At m=14 using k mod14, buckets become 10:[10,24],3:[17],8:[8]. Old positions cannot remain unchanged. Open addressing likewise reinserts using new probe sequences and removes tombstones.

For a fixed unsuccessful query key $x \notin S$ and a fixed stored set S with $|S| = n$, define

$$X = \sum_{y \in S} \mathbf{1}[h(y) = h(x)].$$

Linearity of expectation and universality give

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_{y \in S} \Pr(h(y) = h(x)) \leq n/m.$$

Rehash relocation and expected analysis (continued)

This calculation does not need independence among collision events, but both x and S must be fixed before the function is selected. Adaptive attacks are a different model. If $x \in S$, the self-collision contributes exactly 1, giving the bucket-length bound $1 + (n-1)/m$. The unsuccessful-query bound cannot be reused in that case. A successful-query distribution concentrated on the longest chain cannot inherit the average for uniform queries.

Scanning costs Θ(m+n). When m=Θ(n), bounded load and suitable randomness make reinsertion expected Θ(n). Colliding insertions with duplicate checks may take quadratic time, so worst-case linear rehash is not unconditional. Separate 3/4 growth and 1/4 shrink thresholds plus tombstone cleanup support the combined expected-amortized update guarantee.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Cleanup-threshold counterexample and amortized accounting

```
// m starts at a power-of-two minimum_capacity>=8.
// Before inserting a genuinely absent key:
if n+1>3*m/4: rehash(2*m)
else if deleted>m/8: rehash(m)
// After deleting a present key:
if m>minimum_capacity and n<m/4:
    rehash(max(minimum_capacity,m//2))
// Rehash resets deleted=0 and reinserts all n live entries.
```

Resizing and tombstone cleanup need different triggers. The rule "rebuild at the same capacity if n+deleted+1>3m/4" fails near n=3m/4. Delete one key, giving n=3m/4−1 and deleted=1; reinserting it could reuse that tombstone, but the rule rebuilds immediately. With m=128 and 96 keys, 500 repetitions of deleting and reinserting key 95 cause 500 rebuilds and 47,500 record reinsertions. Constantly many operations cannot pay Θ(m) per repetition.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Cleanup-threshold counterexample and amortized accounting (continued)

The corrected rule cleans at the same capacity only after deleted>m/8, requiring Ω(m) deletions since the previous rebuild. Lookup precedes resizing, so updating an existing value never resizes. A genuinely new key first tests live load 3/4, then the deleted threshold. After every insertion, n+deleted≤7m/8: without rebuilding, n≤3m/4 and deleted≤m/8; rebuilding clears tombstones; reusing one does not increase used slots. Deletion only converts Occupied to Deleted, preserving that sum. Consequently at least m/8 Never-used slots remain even after subsequent deletions.

Growth leaves live load about 3/8, while shrinking leaves it at most 1/2. Reaching the opposite resize threshold requires Ω(m) live-count changes, preventing one-delete/one-insert oscillation. Charge same-capacity cleanup separately to its accumulated deletions. Under the stated uniform-probing or compatible random model, each rebuild costs expected Θ(m+n), giving expected amortized O(1) probe work over updates. Worst-case collisions still allow linear operations or quadratic reinsertion. Odd double-hash steps cover power-of-two capacities, but coverage alone does not establish the ideal random-permutation model.

Overflow and engineering conditions

- In chaining, overflow means longer bucket contents. A full open-addressed table must be detected rather than probed forever.
- Hashing an L-symbol string can cost $\Theta(L)$. Probe count alone omits key-processing time.
- An attacker controlling many colliding keys can invalidate distribution assumptions. Possible responses include random seeds, suitable keyed hashing, or another container.
- Sorted iteration, range queries, and predecessors are more direct with balanced search trees, since hash tables do not preserve key order.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-stu

Sources, verification, and boundaries

- The MIT 6.006 2008 index, L5–L7, identifies hashing course material. Collision and deletion examples are independently designed.
- C++ unordered associative requirements distinguish average from worst-case costs and require compatible hash and equality functions. Average guarantees do not mean worst-case constant time for every call.
- Exercises list slot states, and solutions derive stopping conditions.

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

References and attribution

Ellis Horowitz, Sartaj Sahni, Dinesh Mehta. Fundamentals of Data Structures in C++, 2nd Edition.

Original educational synthesis by Lin Cing. Original material is licensed under CC BY 4.0. The referenced textbook is not distributed with these notes.

https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study

Lin Cing
https://github.com/xinhi6716/computer-science-self-study